



TROOPS PATROL TALIBAN AND AL-QAEDA STRONG-HOLDS IN THE LATEST OFFENSIVE (LEFT); PAKISTAN TALIBAN CHIEF HAKEEMULLAH MEHSUD (CENTRE) IN A FRAME TAKEN FROM A NEWS VIDEO



REUTERS

THE ARMY IS TAKING THE FIGHT TO THE TALIBAN stronghold in a decisive battle against the jihadis. If it fails, the consequences will not remain limited to Pakistan.

most people viewing the spate of terror attacks as the predictable fallout of this commitment. As an air and ground military offensive pushes on in South Waziristan, polls indicate that only 13 per cent of the population opposes the army's thrust into the area.

The US also believes that Al-Qaeda has set up base in parts of North and South Waziristan since 2002, and since 2004 the CIA has been targeting militant leaders with unmanned drones. Such attacks have intensified in the last two years to howls of protest from Pakistanis. However, the Pakistan Army's own attempts to deal with the brutal militancy in the area—which consolidated itself by wiping out a generation of traditional tribal leaders—have, before now, been abject failures.

The army's first three forays into

the region—in 2004, 2006 and 2008—all ended in humiliating climbdowns. Aside from last year, when the operation was aborted before it even began, the army suffered so heavily in 2004 and 2006 that it was forced to sue for peace and cut deals with local warlords. Officials claim this time things will be different. "We have done our spadework this time," says one senior army commander, "We have been preparing for this operation for three months and we have a national political consensus behind us. That is a big difference. The public understands that these terrorists will strike out in desperation but that if this scourge is to be stopped, it must be uprooted."

The "spadework" involved cutting advance deals with other tribal warlords—such as Hafiz Gul Bahadur in

North Waziristan and Maulvi Nazir of the Waziri tribe in South Waziristan, previously allied with the TTP—to remain neutral in the action. "The army realised after the problems of the previous operations that it could not afford to take on all the militants at the same time," says the army source. It has also tried to isolate the Baitullah Mehsud group—now led by his successor Hakeemullah Mehsud—by allying for now with its rivals within the Mehsud tribe, such as the Abdullah Mehsud group and Turkistan Bhittani, whose focus has largely been Afghanistan.

The largely successful Swat operation seems to have convinced the US that the Pakistan military's strategy of isolating the hard core from its less imminently threatening potential sympathisers may not be such a bad tactical